MENGRU WANG

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Fields of Interest

Research: Economic History, Political Economy, Development Economics
Teaching: Microeconomics, Game Theory, Economic History, Chinese Economy

Education

National University of Singapore, Singapore — Aug 2021 – 2027 (expected)
Ph.D. in Economics

University of Chicago, Chicago, United States — Sep 2018 – Jun 2019
Master of Arts in Social Sciences (MAPSS, Economics Concentration)

Peking University, Beijing, China — Sep 2014 – Jul 2018
Bachelor of Economics in Finance (Yuanpei College, Guanghua Track)
Bachelor of Science in Mathematics and Applied Mathematics

Working Papers

Boundary Manipulation in Qing China's Administrative Hierarchy *[Job Market Paper]*

Abstract: How do states draw their administrative boundaries? While geography offers a natural template for administrative division, boundaries are often manipulated to serve political ends. This paper examines boundary manipulation across the administrative hierarchy of Qing China (1644–1911), comparing the provincial and prefectural boundaries of 1820 with hypothetical units constructed from geographical attributes. At the provincial level, I confirm the deliberate manipulation documented in the literature, with the most misaligned provinces lying along the Qinling–Huaihe divide between north and south China. At the prefectural level, I find no evidence of manipulation, as misalignment is spatially diffuse and reflects physiography rather than strategy. The provincial manipulation, moreover, did not penetrate downward, as it operated by reallocating intact prefectures rather than redrawing their boundaries. These findings reveal a tradeoff in boundary design between political stability and administrative efficiency, with the state securing control at the top of the hierarchy while preserving geographical coherence below.

When Peace Made the State: Song China in Comparative Perspective *(with Tuan-Hwee Sng and Shengyi Zhang, draft in preparation)*

Abstract: State capacity is conventionally treated as a scalar. We argue that there are gains from conceptualizing it as comprising two dimensions: reach, the depth of the state's formal administrative and fiscal presence in local society, and coordination, its ability to mobilize resources across jurisdictions for concerted action. We develop a model showing that while the two dimensions tend to go hand in hand in small- and medium-sized polities, they face an organizational tradeoff in large polities, such that strengthening one can weaken the other. In absolute empires, rulers primarily concerned with internal usurpation adopt flat, closely monitored structures that facilitate extraction but constrain military coordination, whereas rulers primarily concerned with threats originating outside the regime adopt hierarchical structures with the opposite properties. Military pressure may therefore reduce, rather than increase, fiscal revenue. We evaluate these predictions through Northern Song (960–1127) and High Qing (1683–1799) China. Our findings help explain the apparent paradox of Song China: a state capable of sustaining a high tax-to-GDP ratio yet organization-

ally constrained in its capacity for military expansion, in contrast to the early modern European states central to bellicist accounts. More broadly, our study delimits the scope of bellicist theories of state formation.

Work in Progress

A Tale of Two Rivers *(with Youhong Lin and Tuan-Hwee Sng)*

Research Experience

Harvard Business School, Boston, United States — Aug 2019 – Jun 2021

Full-time Research Associate for Prof. Laura Alfaro

- Lead research associate on *Omnia Juncta in Uno: Foreign Powers and Trademark Protection in Shanghai's Concession Era* (L. Alfaro, G. Bao, M. Chen, J. Hong, C. Steinwender), studying how legal institutions shaped firm behavior in early twentieth-century Shanghai; additional analyses for Prof. Alfaro's other projects
- Data: cleaning and managing the Shanghai Hong List panel from digitized records; refining firm matching across years and sources; resolving data-quality problems in a reproducible workflow
- Estimation: implementing difference-in-differences, triple-difference, and event-study designs; conducting robustness checks including pre-trend tests, heterogeneity analyses, and alternative specifications
- Delivery: presenting the results to the faculty team every week; producing all tables and figures for the paper

Peking University, Beijing, China — Feb 2017 – Jul 2017

Part-time Research Assistant for Prof. Chong Liu

Conferences and Workshops

Presenter, The 1st International Symposium on Empirical Political Economy and Quantitative Economic History (scheduled)	Nov 2026
Presenter, The 12th Annual Symposium on Quantitative History	Jul 2026
Presenter, The 12th Hong Kong Economic Association Biennial Conference	Jun 2026
Participant, The 8th Asian Historical Economics Conference	Dec 2024
Participant, The 9th Summer School for Quantitative History	Jul 2023

Academic Service

Referee for *Explorations in Economic History* (2 reports), *Economic Systems* (3 reports)	2024 – 2026
Student Facilitator, The 3rd Conference on New Economic History of China	Mar 2026

Teaching Experience

TA, NUS Economics Department Ph.D. Math Camp (taught by faculty from 2026)	Summer 2026
TA, HS2909 The Rise and Fall and Rise of China, with Prof. Tuan-Hwee Sng	Fall 2025
TA, HS2909 The Rise and Fall and Rise of China, with Prof. Tuan-Hwee Sng	Spring 2025
TA, EC3312 Game Theory & Applications to Economics, with Prof. Sam Jindani	Fall 2024
Tutor, Yale-NUS Economics Capstone Program	2024 – 2025
Instructor, NUS Economics Department Ph.D. Math Camp	Summer 2024
TA, EC3101 Microeconomic Analysis II, with Dr. Timothy Wong	Spring 2024
TA, EC3101 Microeconomic Analysis II, with Prof. Tuan-Hwee Sng	Spring 2023

Awards & Scholarships

K.R. Chou PhD Scholarship in Economics, National University of Singapore	2025
Research Scholarship, National University of Singapore	2021 – 2025
Outstanding Graduate, Peking University	2018
Guanghua Scholarship, Peking University	2017, 2018
Li Huirong Scholarship, Peking University	2015, 2016

Miscellaneous

Software: Stata, R, Python, MATLAB, ArcGIS, LaTeX
Languages: English (fluent), Mandarin (native)
Citizenship: China

References

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Timothy Wong (Teaching Reference)
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